

Killer Rigs

PCs for every budget, be it an entry-level one, a HTPC or even a beast of a machine. They're all here

Price Watch

Diwali is here. Bonuses are here as well. So blow your budget on tablets of every size and category you can think of.

Intel or AMD

Which processor mobo combos to buy?

Deciding which to get can be quite the pain

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I've been putting off a few config requests for quite some time because ... um ... GTA V happened. Well it's time to get back on track so I've decided to do a roundup of sorts and list just the processor and motherboard combinations since that's what most dealers are bent on selling you anyways. And don't get me wrong, it's not a bad thing since it does reduce the chances of the customer messing up the generation of AMD and Intel. Every other processor is a i3, i5, i7, A4, A6, A8 or an A10 but little do they notice that the nomenclature has been retained across multiple generations and this has been the bane of our existence. The nomenclature makes sense only for those who spell out the entire model numbers and such but if you call them purely by their segment name (i.e. i5 or A6) then you're bound to get things wrong.

Like all configuration tables even this is subject to modifications depending on your needs. If you need a heck lot of PCI-e cards on an HTPC (for whatever strange



reason it may be) then you can swap out the board I've mentioned and opt for a board with as many PCI-e slots which you may need. What you need to do is ensure that whatever combination that you go for, you should check the motherboards "CPU supported list" to confirm if your processor would be compatible. Motherboards rarely affect performance unless you wish to overclock which is why I've assumed that most users in the mid-range and enthusiast segment would be interested in overclocking their processors. Hence, I've included stable motherboards whose VRM features plenty of power phases.

In a bid to future-proof this list I've included a few processors that are yet to be launched in India but have enjoyed favourable reviews overseas in their respective categories. Also, I don't judge

whether you are an AMD fanboy or an Intel loyalist so I've included both options. The AMD FX-9590 clocked at 4.7GHz with a boost clock of 5GHz should be priced in the same segment as the Core i7-3930K and going by benchmarks should suffice for games that load all available cores. Comparing the same to a 4960X is somewhat

common on the internet but the 4960X is bound to be way ahead given that it costs roughly twice that of the 9590. Similarly, the Haswell i3-4340 should provide slightly better performance than the A10-5800K since early benchmarks have pegged it better at single-threaded and multi-threaded applications. On top of that it has a lower TDP and greater memory bandwidth so it's economical too! But wait, the 5800K has an unlocked multiplier that should help to redeem itself against the i3-4340.

A question that I often have to answer when I mention a certain processor is why not pay the extra ₹1000 and get the next SKU? Well, if you've got money to spare then go ahead by all means but if that same amount could be spent getting a more efficient power supply or cooling fans then that would be the smarter choice from an economic perspective. Given that most of these processors have a turbo mode that kicks in when the extra power is needed it really doesn't make any sense to go for the very next SKU. Also benchmarks show that in most cases two subsequent SKU differ in performance by a meagre amount.

So until next time, do keep sending in e-mails telling me how your configuration is better than mine. Toodles! 

Viable Processor-Motherboard Combos:

	Low	Mid	High	HTPC
CPU	AMD FX-6300	Intel Core i5-4670K	Intel Core i7-3930K	AMD A10-5800K APU
Price in ₹	7,632	17,120	37,999	8,905
Motherboard	ASUS M5A97-R2.0	Gigabyte Z87X-OC	ASRock X79 Extreme6	ASRock FM2A75-DGS
Price	7,295	19,635	19,750	NA
Alternatives				
	Low	Mid	High	HTPC
CPU	Intel i3-3220	AMD FX-8350	AMD FX-9590	Intel i3-4340
Price in ₹	7,900	13,230	TBA	TBA
Motherboard	ASRock Z77M	ASUS Sabertooth 990FX-R2.0	ASUS Sabertooth 990FX-R2.0	Gigabyte Z87N-WiFi
Price	NA	18,389	18,389	NA